



STEPHANIE GRACE LIM/Staff

The Carolina Raptor Center is treating this bald eagle for mercury poisoning. The eagle is too weak to hold its head up.

Bald eagle poisoned by mercury

Ailing bird getting treatment for rare diagnosis at Carolina Raptor Center

By **BRUCE HENDERSON**

Staff Writer

Wobbly on its feet and wracked by tremors, the young bald eagle being nursed at the Carolina Raptor Center is a most disheveled national symbol.

But what makes this bird remarkable is that it's alive at all.

The diagnosis, learned Wednesday after weeks of uncertainty: mercury poisoning.

Mercury, a silver-white metal, is extremely toxic. It can cause brain damage in unborn fetuses and young children. The effect on wildlife is less clear. If victims are

found at all, they're usually dead.

While it occurs naturally, mercury also billows from coal-burning industries and incinerators, spreading through the air and raining back down on waterways.

Eleven N.C. rivers and lakes, mostly near the coast but including Moore County in the state's midsection, are contaminated with mercury. Health officials have issued advisories against eating certain kinds of fish from those waters.

Bald eagles favor fish above all things.

"If it's in the fish, more than

likely it's in the birds too," said Randall Wilson of the N.C. Wildlife Resources Commission.

Few records exist of how often mercury kills eagles because their bodies are rarely found, said Dr. Kathy Converse of the National Wildlife Health Center in Wisconsin. It is known that the birds usually die of malnutrition. Mercury also interferes with metabolism, so the birds aren't nourished by the food they do eat.

Mercury also causes reproductive problems, said Tom Aug-

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Mercury poisoning weakens bald eagle

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spurger, who specializes in environmental contaminants for the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service in Raleigh. Birds make fewer nesting attempts or lay eggs outside the nest, where they won't hatch.

This eagle came from Aurora, a Beaufort County community about halfway up the coast.

The bird had been seen lingering around a fish hatchery for about a month before it was captured, weak and lethargic.

A wildlife rehabilitator kept the bird two weeks before shipping it to the raptor center three weeks ago.

The eagle, about 3 years old and probably a male, has lost its appetite and makes no attempt to fly to a perch in the outdoor pen where it's held.

"It hasn't really changed significantly since his arrival here," said

Mathias Engelmann, the center's rehabilitation coordinator.

A fax brought the diagnosis Wednesday morning. After blood tests ruled out lead poisoning, which is more common, the Louisiana Veterinary Medical Diagnostic Laboratory detected mercury.

"It's the first case we know of here," Engelmann said.

Stanley Apothecary on Monroe Road stocked the hard-to-find treatment drugs, a compound known as DMSA, which the bird will receive orally twice a day for 10 days. Then the blood will be retested. Meantime, the bird also gets fluids to help flush his system, antibiotics and force-feedings of fish.

The prognosis is not clear. The mercury has been in its system for at least five weeks. By the time mercury settles into bone, Converse said from Wisconsin, it's hard to flush back out.